

LANTERN COMMISSION

SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

Death of Keeper M. Teague - Harrow Ness Light Station

REF: LC/INV/87-014

DATE: 14 MAR 1987

1. BACKGROUND

Malcolm Teague served as Principal Keeper at Harrow Ness Light Station until his presumed death on or around 14 November 1986. He was the station's sole resident keeper at the time of the incident.

2. CIRCUMSTANCES

On the night of 14 November 1986, Harrow Ness and surrounding waters experienced severe storm conditions, with sustained winds reaching storm force 10, gusting higher, consistent with Met Office records for the period (Hebrides sea area). Keeper Teague failed to complete his scheduled radio check at 2300 hours. MV Selkie was dispatched at the first available opportunity, delayed by conditions, and reached Harrow Ness on 16 November 1986, whereupon it was found that the light mechanism had sustained storm damage and Keeper Teague was not present at the station.

3. SEARCH AND RECOVERY

A search was conducted by HM Coastguard and local vessels from 16 to 20 November 1986. No trace of Keeper Teague was recovered. Given the severity of conditions and the exposed nature of the station's external walkways, drowning is considered the probable cause of death.

4. FINDINGS

The Commission's investigation found no evidence to suggest the death was other than accidental, occurring in the course of Keeper Teague attempting emergency repairs to maintain the light during severe weather, consistent with established keeper protocol under Commission Order 14(c).

5. RECOMMENDATIONS

The Commission recommends this station be prioritised for conversion to automatic operation, and that protocols for keeper safety during extreme weather at exposed stations be reviewed Commission-wide.

Signed on behalf of the Lantern Commission Board of Inquiry.